

STAGE SIXTEEN • WORKPLACE PROFESSIONALISM & ETHICS

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR NOTES / SCRIPT

Suggested language for openings, transitions, and prompting discussion

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Facilitator Notes / Script

Stage Sixteen • Workplace Professionalism & Workplace Readiness / Professional Ethics & Integrity

HOW TO USE THIS SCRIPT

This document is written for a first-time or less confident facilitator who wants actual suggested language, not just a topic list. Everything in quotes is meant to be read close to verbatim, or adapted lightly into your own voice.

Stage Sixteen is the largest stage in the program, and its final two sessions (Ethical Foundations & Responsibilities, Applied Ethics & Integrity Reflection) ask for real honesty about ethical choices, some genuinely uncomfortable. Part 4 of this script is especially important here — review it before facilitating, not just during.

It's organized into four parts: session openings, transitions between FIRSTS, discussion prompting for five specific situations, and tricky moments flagged at specific FIRSTS where participants commonly get uncomfortable, stuck, or reluctant to share.

Part 1 — Session Openings

Opening Session 1

"Welcome to Stage Sixteen. This is the trust layer underneath everything else in the program — your skills, your leadership, your business acumen all depend on people trusting your reliability and your character."

"This is also our biggest single stage, forty-five FIRSTS across five sessions. We're going to move at a genuine pace today, but Sessions 4 and 5 later on will ask for more room and more honesty than these first few."

Opening Session 2

"Last time was about building good habits. Today is about harder, more specific situations — confidentiality, boundaries, escalation, mistakes, accountability conversations. These are the moments habits alone don't fully prepare you for."

Opening Session 3

"Today shifts from what you do to how it's actually perceived: performance, feedback, reputation, culture, and a standard you set for yourself. Some of today's work requires a real conversation with a real colleague outside this room — I'll flag exactly when."

Opening Session 4

"We're moving from professionalism into ethics today. This session asks for more honesty than the first three — real ethical difficulty, real pressure, real moments the truth was uncomfortable to say. Nothing here requires you to disclose specifics to the group; I'll always tell you clearly when something is opt-in."

"This is one of our two longest sessions. If we need to split it across two meetings, that's a completely reasonable call — I'd rather we go deep than rush through it."

Opening Session 5 (Stage Close)

"Our final session applies everything from Session 4 to real, lived pressure, and closes out the entire stage — both the professionalism half and the ethics half together."

"Bring your Professional Standard Statement from Session 3 if you have it — we're going to check it honestly against your real, recent behavior later today."

Part 2 — Transitions Between FIRSTS

A few sentences said out loud between exercises and between sessions turns a checklist into a coherent narrative.

FIRST T2 → T3

"You've built a routine that's yours. Now let's look outward — the unwritten rules and etiquette that shape how that routine is actually received by others."

FIRST T6 → T7

"We just looked at owning outcomes you were already responsible for. Ownership Experience goes one step further — solving something no one assigned you at all."

Session 1 → Session 2

"Today built genuine habits: routine, punctuality, ownership, initiative. Next session moves into harder, more specific situations those habits alone don't fully prepare you for."

FIRST T14 → T15

"We just covered knowing when to ask for help. Mistake Recovery is the mirror image — what to do once something's already gone wrong."

Session 2 → Session 3

"You've built judgment for hard situations. Today looks at something related but distinct — how your overall performance and character are actually perceived over time."

FIRST T24 → T25

"You've honestly assessed your readiness. Now let's turn that into something forward-looking — a standard you're committing to hold yourself to, whether or not anyone's checking."

Session 3 → Session 4

"Everything so far has been professionalism — habits, judgment, reputation. Today we move to ethics: the deeper principles that guide you when there's no clear policy to follow."

FIRST T33 → T34

"We just covered giving credit where it's due. Now let's look at something related but harder — telling the truth even when it's genuinely uncomfortable to do so."

Session 4 → Session 5

"You've built real ethical awareness and analyzed a genuine dilemma. Today is about applying that under real pressure, and closing the loop on everything from this entire stage."

FIRST T40 → T41

"You've just defined the ethical principles you want your leadership to reflect. Now let's honestly check: does your recent behavior actually match the broader standard you set back in Session 3?"

Part 3 — Prompting Discussion in the Moment

Five situations that come up often in this specific stage, with suggested language for each.

A participant is reluctant to name a real workplace mistake for T15

“You don't have to describe what happened in detail. Just naming honestly whether your recovery focused on ownership or on hiding it is enough for today.”

Someone says their organization doesn't have clear speak-up channels (T42)

“That's genuinely useful to know, and worth raising with HR or a manager directly. In the meantime, a direct conversation with a trusted manager is almost always an available starting point, even without a formal channel.”

A participant becomes visibly uncomfortable during the Integrity Decision reflection (T27)

“This is genuinely one of the harder reflections in the program. You're welcome to write your answer privately rather than share it — the value is in your own honest reckoning, not in telling the group.”

Someone argues that a clearly unethical shortcut is “not a big deal” during group discussion

“I hear that it might feel small in the moment. Let's use the framework from T35: what are the actual competing values at stake here, even in a small case?”

The room goes quiet during the T45 full-stage reflection

“That's okay — this is asking you to look honestly across forty-five FIRSTS, not just today's session. Take a real moment before we go around.”

Part 4 — Tricky Moments by FIRST

Four specific FIRSTS (one covering two closely related items) where participants commonly get stuck, defensive, or reluctant — and language to navigate each moment.

FIRST T22

Professional Reputation Audit

FACILITATOR NOTE

This requires a real conversation with a real colleague outside the session and can surface a genuinely uncomfortable gap between self-perception and reality. Frame it explicitly as launched today, followed up on independently, and check in briefly at the start of Session 4.

FIRST T27 & T39

Integrity Decision / Accountability Under Pressure

FACILITATOR NOTE

These ask participants to honestly assess real past ethical choices, sometimes ones they're not proud of. Never require group disclosure of specifics. If someone volunteers a genuinely difficult real story, thank them for their honesty and keep the group's response supportive, not judgmental.

FIRST T34

Professional Honesty Challenge

FACILITATOR NOTE

Participants may realize, in real time, that they're currently avoiding an uncomfortable truth they should address. Let this land without pressuring anyone to commit to immediate action in front of the group — the private commitment is what matters.

FIRST T42

Speak-Up Awareness

FACILITATOR NOTE

Some participants may have a genuine, current concern they're unsure how to raise, which this FIRST can surface unexpectedly. If something serious comes up, follow your own organization's or program's guidance for handling disclosures, and offer a private conversation rather than addressing specifics in the group.